# A Vernacular View

In this essay I would like to reevaluate what happened in the process of the widespread adoption of computational intelligence and its subsequent violent omnipresence. I try to think a different approach to this practice, speculatively moving around its roots and reevaluating its relation to the world. Critiquing the contemporary practice of machine learning and the industries it has spawned with all the harm they caused, I go on to propose a shift in perspective about these algorithms that might serve to change their use and adoption. The main themes I engage with are Opacity and Transparency. The adoption or rejection of these two ideas by systems of computational intelligence, I believe are vital to shaping what they are or how they could be.

The mathematical interpretation of neural networks as function approximators carries with it some aspect of magic, that is, the idea that there is a computable 'secret' function to almost any part of reality we can imagine and form as a problem to be solved. These functions, forming topological sites to be discovered, not through analysis, but rather algorithms designed to experience and subsequently approximate them (Cavia, 2022). There is a destructive generalizing quality to this approximation, however, which lends itself to the many violent uses of intelligent systems acting in the real world, by expecting of it transparency and interpretability and so in the process of this assumption, destroying everything that is left opaque in it (Blas, 2018). This logic of total transparency and rationality, the transformation of subjects of the world into categorizable objects of western knowledge is the barbaric modus operandi of the west, which computational intelligence has become a victim of. The fundamental approximating nature of neural nets in resonance with informatic standardization. I reject this modality of computational intelligence and exclaim our desire for their Opacity, a term coined by Édouard Glissant, that I deem to be that, which protects the diverse (Blas, 2018).

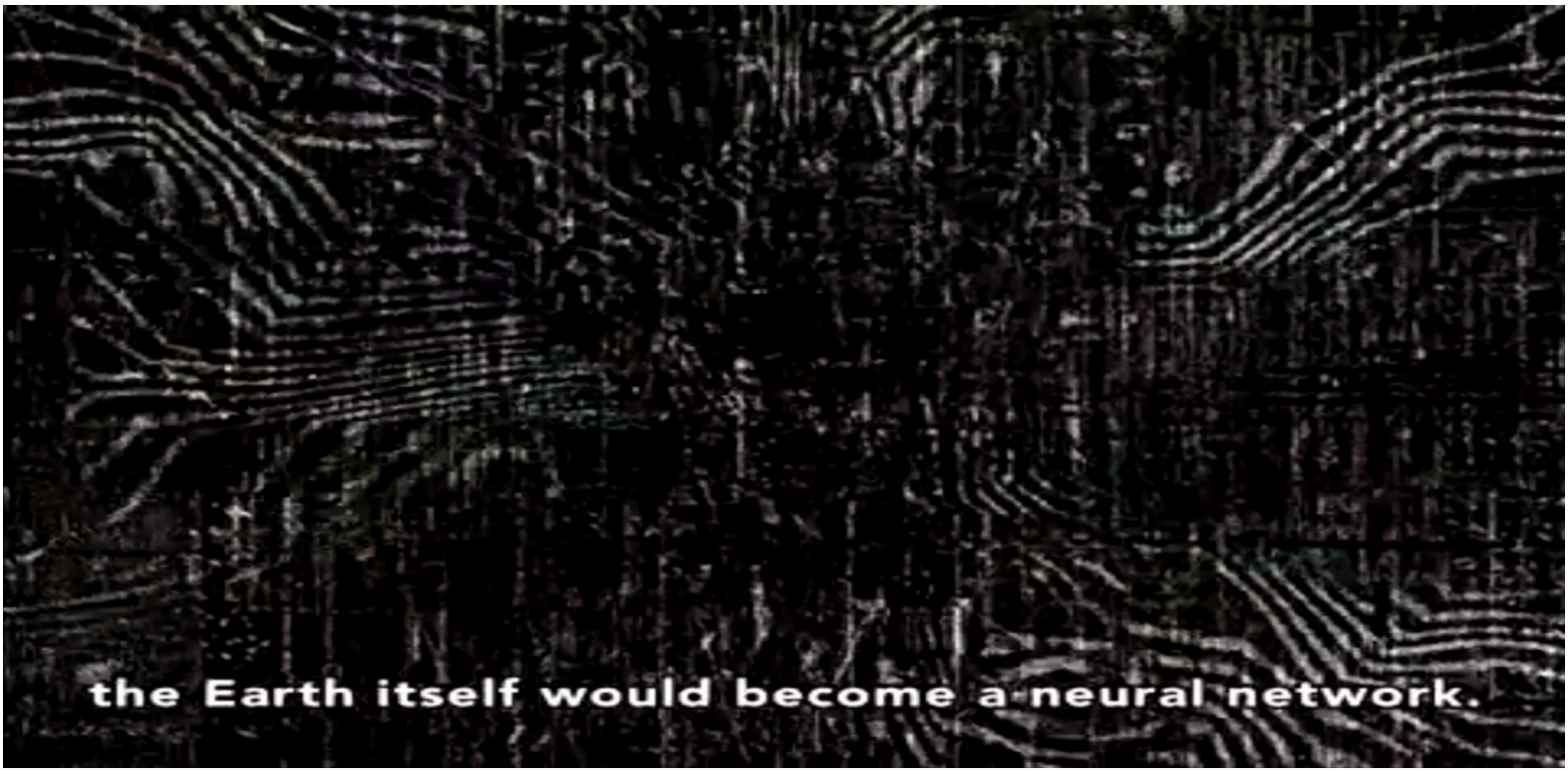
I imagine the neural network model, as an observer of its own imagined reality (topological site), constructed through its parametric interpretation of the learning dataset. The model is a subject submerged in its own delusions. It is the creator of its own difference, entitled to it and the Opacity that comes with it. It observes the data and embeds each piece into a latent space of a larger relational capacity and so, for better or worse, invents its own context. This space is continuous, meaning that even its empty parts become relational. In generative models these empty spaces sometimes take on cryptic, unexplainable forms with respect to the learning dataset. The models are, in a sense, inventing their own 'lore' (De Seta, 2024). Here I agree with (Parisi, 2018), that intelligence is primarily an alien affair, an engine of abstraction forcing a constant de-naturalization from what is given. The same happens inside image generation models, in tandem with their associated datasets. The dataset serves to remove the source image out of its original context and the model embeds it into a new one. We believe the Opacity of neural network models is inevitable and instead of forcing upon these systems new standardization, we should instead embrace the potential for specificity and opaqueness, which they possess by their design.

Thinking on a broader level of technics in general, Zach Blass terms Informatic Opacity as the practice of anti-standardization at the global, technical scale (Blass, 2018). Models of computational intelligence should be one of the main considerations of this application of Opacity. We would like to see computational intelligence that expresses the joy of Opacity and does not, instead, facilitate its destruction. Instead of looking for generalizable solutions to any problems imaginable and subsequently using neural models as the "one fits all" solution, I instead imagine a system of specificity. "Intelligent" models that embrace the niche context of use, be it whatever. In a way, trapping the model in it's own opaque difference. Something that also comes with critical dataset practices. A situated approach of "foraging" for data, where it might lie and not relying on institutions or the colossus of academia to provide it. I see the joy in Opacity of computational intelligence in the awe this processes leave us in, when we see them work and perform their computational magic. It is a power that, just like any other can be exploited at various levels of the class system. I want to imagine this power in the hands of the people instead of corporations, as articulated in the passages above I believe it is the profit driven circumstances shaped by hungry corporations that have in large shaped contemporary computational intelligence, by

creating the generalizing forces that have flattened the use of these systems instead of seeing their rich potential in embracing situatedness. Here then, I propose the vernacular view.

Vernacular creativity, emerging from unpredictable encounters between intelligent systems and their users, a kind of folklore that is not only digitally mediated, but also shaped by learning algorithms already exists and can be seen clearly to a lot of us (De Seta, 2024). Just like how the popularization of personal computers and information networks has come with their own digital vernaculars, the same can be observed with the increasing participation of neural networks in online vernacular activities. Except neural networks seem to be exhibiting “lore” of their own with unexplainable mystic cryptids that captivate the interest of the internet. Precisely because these systems generate their own context, which sometimes leads to unpredictable, murky, unexplainable behaviors and outputs, perfect for lore hungry netizens online, which is a an ideal catalyst for forming communities around any and every point of connection between people. The prevalence of neural network algorithms, together with their lack of transparency had rendered them to become modern myths. Even if the resources behind these systems are centrally controlled and the architectures and algorithms are fine tuned to still serve their interests, vernacular creativity has emerged nonetheless. One starts to question how this could look like in the case of a different form of adoption of this technology.

I therefore exclaim the right of artificially intelligent systems to Informatic Opacity, the practice of anti-standardization at the global, technical scale (Blass, 2018) within the systems themselves too. The right to protect Opacities is the right to protect difference, and for poetics to emerge from the interaction between these differences. Opacities can coexist and converge, weaving fabrics. (Glissant and Wing, 1997). Relation, which is what the world makes and expresses of itself, can exist between all actors of our world, of which technologies have for long become an important part of. Through the chaos of this network of relations we weave cultures, myths and folklore. For this interactive relation between actors to bear any poetics, distance is required, as otherwise we fall into the trap of requesting interpretability and generalization which, as far as poetics goes, is a violent destruction, a barbarism that destroys the opacity of the subject. Still computers are not capable of following the flow of cultures, the poetic nodes, the dynamics of languages, the phases of cultures in confrontation. Should we hope that our imaginary construct of Relation might someday be "confirmed" in formulas we can read on the monitor screen? Can accident, which is the joy of poetics, be tamed through circuits? With artificial intelligence an answer becomes available (Glissant and Wing, 1997). There will be no formulas derived or interpretability, instead the best we can hope for is for systems to participate in the poetics of our world. Poetics can not be tamed, but they can be embraced.



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